

The Eco-Spiritual Philosophy of the Living Forest

Forest School Concept — Co-Created — 2026

Michel Garand with the host household | 2026-09-27 | Version v0.8 | CC BY-SA 4.0

Grounding document of the Carpathian OER Commons, published as a working draft and open to co-creation. It speaks from conviction. The guide does not claim what it holds as results; the foundations paper, Sections 3 and 8, says where each conviction stands against the evidence. No child is named, dated, counted, or placed; all programme description is standing-format and undated. Points of Hutsul practice are marked [for the elders]: they wait on the elders to confirm, correct, or withhold them.

v0.8, 2026-09-27: prepared for publication — Hutsul points marked for the elders; the opening line of Section VI removed.

This concept is co-created, and so is this text. Its Hutsul heart — the worldview, the grief-forms, the tenets' deepest roots — comes from the host household's own vision for the school; the learning architecture comes from the Soil and Peace and Pattern Language of Place work. Neither stands without the other, and neither hand owns the page: this is a common working draft that either author may change, passed between us until it is common ground. Nothing here is final until both hands have let it rest — and only then does it travel.

I. The Child at the Centre

Everything in this philosophy is measured first by one thing: the transformation within the child. The forest is regenerated, trees are planted, springs are cleared — and all of it stands as the tangible, physical reflection of an inner healing, never as an abstract goal beside it. The natural world acts as co-therapist and mirror: what the child tends outwardly is what mends inwardly.

Five movements of the child's recovery order the work:

- **Safety first.** Acute anxiety lowered; basic trust rebuilt; a child's inner sense of agency, groundedness, and personal boundary restored. Nothing else begins until the ground of safety holds.
- **The senses reopened.** War numbs. Recovery begins as sensory reawakening — the texture of soil, pine scent on the wind, stillness that no longer threatens, joy relearned through the body before it is spoken.
- **Purpose and identity redefined.** The child's self-perception moves from "victim of war" to creator, defender, and steward of life on their native land. This is not asked of the child; it grows from what the child does and sees themselves doing.
- **Faith in light and goodness restored.** Inner resilience grows through belonging to something larger than oneself — living, enduring, and held sacred by the community around the child.
- **A flourishing forest as living proof.** Ecological regeneration is the derived outcome and the visible testimony: the forest thrives, and its thriving tells the child a truth no words could carry — *you have the power to nurture, to heal, and to give life back to the world.*

The school's part in this is the gardener's part. The programme heals no one and teaches no one in the old sense; it prepares ground, keeps rhythm, and accompanies. The healing is done by the forest, the circle, and the child, at the child's own pace.

II. Roots in the Wisdom of the World

The philosophy is grounded in deep human wisdom and experience, drawn together in a contemporary, non-dogmatic synthesis — and ordered so that the local tradition leads and the world's traditions stand beside it as kin.

The Hutsul worldview is the taproot. The highlands hold a deep animism — mountains, waters, and trees as living presences — and a tradition that meets death itself with community, games, laughter, and song: the night vigils in which grief is confronted together until the fear of death is defeated. From this the school draws its boldest medicine: grief transformed through archaic games, polyphonic singing, ritual dance, and the celebration of the eternal cycle of life. [for the elders]

The ways of the Indigenous peoples of Turtle Island — the many nations of North America, each distinct, whose publicly shared teachings the school receives with gratitude and by name. From the Haudenosaunee: the Thanksgiving Address, words of gratitude spoken before all else until the minds of the gathered are one, and the Seventh Generation principle, every decision weighed for the children of children not yet born. From the Lakota: *mitákuye oyás'īŋ* — all my relations — the whole living world named as family. From the Potawatomi teaching of the Honourable Harvest: never take the first, never take more than half, ask permission, use everything taken, give a gift in return. What the school draws: its morning circle of gratitude, its planting for children who will never meet the planters, its refusal of the word "wilderness," and its ethic for every act of taking all stand in deep kinship with these ways — a kinship the school names openly and with respect. The companion survey, *The Forest in the World's Wisdom*, holds the fuller account.

The old ways of Europe's north and east, and the peoples of the Urals and beyond stand nearest of all in blood and fate. The Baltic peoples kept a whole cosmology alive in song — the dainas — and in living memory faced down an empire singing; the Mari of the middle Volga still hold Europe's last openly practised grove-faith; the Khanty and Mansi, far kin of the Finns and Hungarians, answer the gravest occasions with nights of songs, stories, and games — the same deep shape as the valley's own vigils, arising at the other end of the Finno-Ugric world; and in the Bashkir epic the hero gives the water of life to the land itself, his body become the Ural Mountains. These are named as peoples, never empires — many survived the same power Ukraine resists — and the companion survey holds their full account.

The Japanese forest way — nature as sacred space, and shinrin-yoku, forest bathing, as cleansing of body and mind — gives the school its practice of sensory immersion: silent meditative walks, trees met as living, feeling beings capable of absorbing pain.

The Daoist way — the living flow of things, naturalness, action through non-striving — gives the school its manner: learning through patient observation, adapting to life's rhythms, softness cultivated as true inner strength. The forest is allowed to work at its own pace, and so is the child.

Biophilia and eco-spirituality — the innate human need for connection with living systems, spirituality expressed through care rather than dogma — give the school its plainest creed: a practical faith rooted in action, hands in the soil, direct responsibility for a piece of the homeland.

Beneath them all runs the oldest human pattern: across cultures and ages, people crossed out of the settled world into the forest — accompanied by a guide, an elder, a healer — and returned changed, carrying something the community needed. The school keeps that shape and holds it gently: accompanied crossing, threshold, return — without ordeal, and with every child's own faith walking beside them unasked. And one rule governs every kinship named here, as it governs the companion survey in full: the school honours by parallel, never by imitation — it sings its own place's songs, and greets the world's by name.

III. The Tenets of the Living Forest

Tenet 1 — The Forest as a Living Temple, Without Walls or Dogmas

The true temple is not built of stone; it lives. The forest accepts every child unconditionally — without judgement, without asking about their past, their trauma, or their beliefs. It offers sanctuary, silence, and safety for renewal of body and spirit. And because the temple has no walls, it has no doctrine: the school's convictions are lived in the open where every family can see and choose them, and no belief is ever pressed on a child. The temple is entered by putting hands in the soil.

Tenet 2 — Carpathian Shinrin-Yoku: Bathing in Life

Reconnection begins in the five senses — and the child has far more than five. War numbs the senses in layers, and the forest reopens them in layers.

First, the senses of the body's own life: touch against rough bark; balance regained on uneven mountain ground; the feel of one's own movement in climbing, carrying, digging; and the quiet inner sense of wellbeing — the felt knowledge *I am alive, and in this moment I am well* — which terror silences first and the forest restores first.

Then, the senses that meet the world: pine breathed on the wind; spring water tasted; the warmth of sun and of fire; light watched moving through the canopy; mountain wind and birdsong heard in a silence that no longer threatens.

And at last, the senses that only meet another person: hearing a voice, understanding the thought that lives behind the words, perceiving the living presence of another I. These are the senses war wounds through sirens and betrayal — and the circle, the song, and the elders are how they reopen.

In the school's learning architecture this whole sensorium is the ground floor of everything: the body as the first instrument, bare attention as the first practice, and nothing demanded of the child but presence. Awareness — the first stage of every path the school walks — begins as bathing in life, with every sense the child has.

Tenet 3 — The Laws of the Tree's Wisdom: Roots, Trunk, Canopy

Every tree teaches survival and dignity, and teaches it three-fold:

- **Roots** — ancestral memory, history, the deep strength of a people who have endured hard times before and endured them standing.
- **Trunk** — inner resilience, moral fibre, the conscious choice to stand tall through the storm.
- **Canopy** — thought, dream, and active care extended outward, sheltering others.

The tree's three-fold is the school's own: what was, what is, what is coming; memory received, strength practised, care given forward. Other peoples read the same tree — the Norse cosmos stood as Yggdrasil, the Sakha epic raises the great world tree — for the lesson is written in every trunk. A child who learns to read a tree this way is reading their own becoming.

Tenet 4 — Care as the Highest Prayerful Action

True spirituality is measured not by doctrine but by loving action. A child's truest prayer is hands in the earth: planting a seedling, clearing a spring, steadying a peer who struggles. For this reason the school uses no reward and no punishment to produce participation — an act done for a prize is obedience, and prayer cannot be obeyed into being. Care is the school's only currency, and it circulates until no one in the circle is only a giver or only a receiver.

Tenet 5 — The Generation of Regeneration

Ukrainian youth are not a lost generation of war. They are the Generation of Regeneration. By tending their homeland — its soil, its forests, its springs, its songs — children discover an identity no one can assign and no war can revoke: *I am part of this land, its guardian, and the builder of its future*. The school exists so that this discovery can be made by each child in their own hands, at their own pace, on native soil.

Tenet 6 — Transformation of Pain: Song, Dance, and the Triumph of Life

The highlands know something the clinics are only now learning: grief that stays in the body must leave through the body. And the valley is not alone in knowing it: at the far end of the Finno-Ugric world, the bear festival of the Khanty and Mansi answers awe and grief with nights of games and song, and in

living memory the Baltic peoples faced down an empire singing — and won. From the ancestral tradition in which community defied despair together through night-long vigil, game, and song [for the elders], the school draws its forms for releasing trauma rather than suppressing it:

- **Singing out the pain.** Polyphonic singing and traditional lament let trapped grief and terror leave the body through breath and shared resonance — voices holding what no single voice could.
- **Dancing out the trauma.** Rhythmic stomping and circle dances release what war froze into the muscles, restoring the body's power and joy in movement.
- **Songs that bless.** Sessions close with bright, rising traditional songs — the old incantations of destiny turned toward life, joy, and the child's own future.
- **The triumph of life.** As the ancestors defied death around the ritual fire, the children learn in their bones what the tradition always taught: darkness passes; life endures.

Two hands hold these forms together, always: the tradition-bearers of the valley, who carry the songs, dances, and games and judge their fitting use; and the programme's qualified psychological staff, who hold each child's safety within them. Every practice is entered freely, never required; grief is invited, never extracted; and a child who only watches from the circle's edge is honoured exactly where they stand. The tradition supplies the medicine; the clinical presence guards the dose.

IV. The Wheel of the Year

The school does not run against the year; it runs with it. Camps can be held in any season — and the season, not the programme, sets the work.

Planting has its windows: in these mountains, the weeks after the spring thaw and the weeks before the autumn frost. The school honours them absolutely. A seedling planted out of season to satisfy a schedule is a programme serving itself; the land's calendar outranks ours, and teaching children exactly that is worth more than any planting. When the window stands open, the cohorts plant. When it is closed, they do the season's own work — and every season has its own:

- **Spring** — sowing and planting; opening the cleared springs; the beds prepared through winter receive their seed.
- **Summer** — tending and watering; the meadow rhythm of the highlands; watching seed ripen; the forest at full voice.
- **Autumn** — the harvest of seed for cohorts to come; the second planting window; clearing, and composting the year's clearing back into the ground.
- **Winter** — the elders' season: craft, story, and song by the fire; rest, as the land itself rests; the forest read in snow, where tracks reveal the lives that summer hides; tools mended, plans laid, the next year's beds made ready.

A cohort that arrives outside the planting windows loses nothing and learns the most: their gathered seed waits through the cold, and a later cohort sets it in the ground — inheritance made literal across the turning year. The Evening of Light takes the colour of its season, for fire in midwinter says what it cannot say in June. And the three-beat movement runs at the year's own scale — autumn clears, winter composts, spring builds — so that the school's one movement now sounds at four scales together: the forest, the child, the session, the year.

V. From Philosophy to Programme

This philosophy is not an annex to the Forest School programme; it is the programme's inner side. The five movements of the child's recovery (Section I) are what the programme's components serve: the Morning Circle and forest immersion build safety and reopen the senses; the regeneration work and the Hack for Hope workshop rebuild purpose and agency; the Elders' Toloka and the grief-forms of Tenet 6 restore belonging, memory, and the triumph of life; the Evening of Light and Seeds of Hope mark the threshold and send each child home carrying proof. The learning architecture — the concentric rings, the fourfold pathway of Awareness, Acknowledgment, Attitude, and Action, the three-beat movement of clearing, composting, and building, the dialogue of the body's senses with simple measurement, and the sense of place that all of them serve — gives the philosophy its daily working form, with no reward and no punishment anywhere in it. The programme document states the architecture, deliverables, and safeguards in full; two companion surveys — of the world's kin wisdom, and of kin schools and initiatives worldwide — hold the lineage; this document states the reason they all exist.

VI. What This Is, and Is Not

Spoken publicly, it is what its practice shows: an eco-spiritual philosophy of the living forest — a manifesto of native land. It founds no church, ordains no one, and competes with no family's faith; a child of any belief, or none, walks the same forest and is equally received. What it keeps of religion is what religion itself once drew from the forest: reverence, threshold, community, song, and the practice of belonging to something greater and living. It is a faith measured only in action — and its only sacrament is care.

Release record

- **Gate 1:** 2026-09-27, the household, as the second hand of this text, recorded by Michel Garand — for publication online as a working draft, open to co-creation and to change.
- **Wartime review:** 2026-09-27, Michel Garand — names Soil and Peace and no place; programme described in standing format only; accepted.

